Permission: I hereby give Henok Girma permission to use the text "How to Write a Philosophy Essay" (dated July 19, 2019) in his teaching at the Royal Institute of Technology during the fall semester of 2021. The text may not be externally distributed or published. If other teachers want to use the text in the future, they need to contact me first. I will almost certainly agree to it.

Citation: Ahlin Marceta, J. (2019). "How to Write a Philosophy Essay". Unpublished teaching material.

In-text citation: Ahlin Marceta (2019).

Jesper Ahlin Marceta. October 25, 2021.

How to Write a Philosophy Essay

Jesper Ahlin Marceta

Philosophical writing is difficult. The aim of writing philosophy is to communicate an abstract and often complex message efficiently. Among other things, it requires pedagogical sensitivity and clarity of thought. This texts explains how students should think when writing philosophy essays at university level. It has four main sections. In the first section, I explain three expectations that philosophy teachers have on their students' essays. Thereafter, I introduce some of the basics of argumentative analysis, which is a major part of the methods of philosophy. The subsequent section treats justification, and how students should go about to justify their views. In the final main section, I spell out some suggestions as to how to do the actual writing. A brief final section concludes.

The teacher's expectations

Philosophy teachers expect (1) that their students have basic knowledge of the topic they are writing about, including the background and context, (2) that they are able to independently choose a problem to treat in their essay which is in fact possible to treat within the given limits in terms of deadline and page numbers, and (3) that their arguments are clear, valid, and sound.

Regarding 1, having basic knowledge of a topic in philosophy means a number of things. First, one must know what it is that philosophers find

© J. Ahlin Marceta — jahlinmarceta.com July 19, 2019

interesting about the topic. What is the main philosophical problem? Why is it a *philosophical* problem and not an empirical, mathematical, theological, or some other kind of problem? Furthermore, one gains from being able to explain the history of the problem. Why did a philosophical discussion about it first appear? Who are the major thinkers that have contributed to this discussion? What are their contributions? And, finally, one should understand why it is relevant to treat the problem today. Does it arise in new settings? Can progress within the discussion further some other cause, such as new developments in physics or sociology? Is it a matter of philosophical curiosity?

Regarding 2, the capability of independently choosing a problem that is in fact possible to treat within the given limits is central. Choosing a problem that is too big might signal ambition, but also a lack of understanding or appreciation of the complexities involved. Choosing a problem that is too small could instead signal disinterest. Philosophical expertise does not only mean that one is competent to treat philosophical problems, but also that one has a sense of what is treatable.

Finally, regarding 3, teachers expect *clarity*, *validity*, and *soundness* in the argumentation. The notion of clarity is straightforward; it means that one's arguments are not obscure. There should be no confusions regarding the aim of the essay or how it is reached. An essay is often more clear if the student writes, "I will argue that *x*, *y*, and *z*," and argues that *x*, *y*, and *z* using terms and concepts that she understands perfectly. Also, the concepts used should not be vague or ambiguous. A concept is *vague* if it is not sufficiently delimited, and *ambiguous* if it carries more meanings than one; both entail uncertainty.

The notions of validity and soundness are more technical than the notion of clarity. I will treat them in a separate section below.

Argumentative analysis

Many first-year philosophy students begin their studies with an introductory course in argumentative analysis. In that course, they practice their skills in identifying the various components in an argument, such as *theses*, *antitheses*, *supporting theses*, and so on. They practice their

skills in argumentative analysis because arguing is what philosophers do; it is a significant share of their *method*.

Very often, students who write philosophy essays have not had this opportunity first. They take individual courses in, for instance, the philosophy of science or research ethics, as part of their university programs and are thus expected to do philosophy without first having been taught the methods of doing philosophy. Many find this difficult. Therefore, this section offers a crash course in the basics of argumentative analysis.

Theses and antitheses

The aim of a philosophy essay should be to discuss one (and preferably only one) main thesis. A thesis is a claim, such as "it is wrong to murder innocents for fun" and "there is no free will."

It should be possible to treat the thesis *intelligently*, by which I mean that it should be possible to consider rational and meaningful reasons for and against it. Examples of theses which are *not* intelligent in this sense include "unicorns smell like rainbows" and "on this day exactly 10 000 years ago, a woman named Ayla had eggs for breakfast." There are no rational and meaningful reasons speaking either for or against them.

For every intelligent thesis there is at least one *antithesis*, i.e., a claim that counters it, such as "it is *not* wrong to murder innocents for fun" and "there *is* a free will." A well-considered argument takes antitheses into account; either they are discussed, or it is explained why not.

Theses generally have *supporting* theses. One supporting thesis for the claim that it is wrong to murder innocents for fun is that people have a right not to be murdered. A philosophy essay should aim to present a main thesis, defend it by explicating supporting theses, and identify and discuss relevant antitheses. There is often not One Absolute Thesis that supports the main thesis, but rather A Set of Reasonable Theses that are coherent and in combination provide convincing support for it. Therefore, it is often wise to seek and defend an overall attitude in favor of the main thesis instead of making claims about absolute certainty.

Definitions

A teacher once told me, "you can refer to a one-way ticket to Paris as 'a red dress with white dots' if you want, but you may encounter difficulties at the booking office." The lesson is that words are not important other than as means for communication, and that it is therefore important that people have the same understanding of the words they use in conversation. In philosophical writing, words should be clearly defined and the definitions adhered to, so that their meanings remain unchanged throughout the essay.

Usually, definitions are either *lexical* or *stipulative*. Lexical definitions are those that appear in a dictionary, or simply ordinary words as they are commonly used. Stipulative definitions, to the contrary, are given a meaning for a specific purpose or context.

Consider this example of a stipulative definition: "In this essay, *shoe* is defined as *a glove for the foot*." The word or concept which is defined, in this case "shoe," is called *definiendum*. The words or concepts which define it, in this case "a glove for the foot," are called *definiens*. Terms in the definiens should also be defined. For instance, if one does not know what "glove" or "foot" means the definition of "shoe" is uninformative. If the same terms appear in both the definiendum and the definiens, such as in the definition "a *coffee machine* is a *machine that makes coffee*," the definition may be circular and for that reason uninformative.

It is often a good idea to stick to definitions that are common in the literature on the topic that the essay treats so as to not confuse the reader. There are various philosophy dictionaries and encyclopedias available both in print and online that are often useful both to students and researchers. One example of an online encyclopedia is the *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*, which is available at https://plato.stanford.edu.

Validity and soundness

Validity is a technical term in philosophy, which means that there is a common formal understanding of it. An argument is understood to be valid *if and only if* it takes a form that makes it impossible for the premises to be true and the conclusion false. Consider this example of a valid argument:

A	All men are mortal
B	Socrates is a man
C	Socrates is mortal

The form of the argument is such that if the two premises *A* and *B* are true the conclusion *C* is true as well. Note that an argument must not be true to be valid. Consider this example of a valid but false argument:

A	All birds can fly
B	Penguins are birds
C	Penguins can fly

The argument is valid, but one of its premises is false (namely *A*). Therefore, the conclusion is also false. In philosophy, the common formal understanding of valid but false arguments is that they are *unsound*.

Thus, validity and soundness are technical terms which may greatly improve a detailed analysis of an argument. Students who aim to rebut an argument should make it clear whether it is the validity, soundness, or something else that is wrong with the argument in question. Naturally, they should also try to view their own arguments in these terms.

Justification in philosophy

Justification is key in any intellectual enterprise aiming for reliability. As scientists seek to justify empirical claims about the world, philosophers seek to justify philosophical claims about it. In this section, I discuss the basics of philosophical justification, with special focus on *moral* justification.

Justification and truth

To justify a claim is to propose convincing reasons in favor of it. For instance, the claim that the earth is round is justified because there are strong reasons supporting it, such as results from experiments, mathematical calculations, and accounts from people who have been to space and observed the shape of our planet.

Claims must not be true to be justified. Claims of truth and claims of justification belong to different categories. Consider, for instance, physics before the revolution of the theory of relativity.

People in the 17th through 19th century were justified in basing their claims about physical bodies in motion on Isaac Newton's mechanics. They had sufficient reason to think and act as if Newton's mechanics were globally valid, although later generations of theoretical physicists have learned that some of those claims were not actually true. Therefore, later generations are *not* justified in basing some claims on Newton's mechanics; more precisely, mainly claims about things at very small scale or at very high velocities. Among other things, contemporary theoretical physicists must take Albert Einstein's theory of relativity in to account.

Thus, claims may be justified in spite of the fact that they are not true. This is not always the case. In mathematics, for instance, it is not justified to claim that 2 + 2 = 5, simply because it is false. Mathematics is an intellectual enterprise in which justification and truth are often more closely connected than what they are in most other cases. In the empirical sciences, such as medicine, biology, and economics, justification concerns reason-giving rather than truth. This is also the case in the humanities, such as history, literature, and philosophy; in these fields, professionals aim to provide convincing reasons in favor of particular views.

This does not mean that there are no truths in these fields. Obviously, there are truths about, for instance, how the human body functions, i.e., biology, and who murdered the Swedish prime minister Olof Palme in 1986, i.e., history. The argument here is merely that claims about some things may be justified in spite of the fact that the truth is unknown.

Foundationalism

As I see things, there are two main approaches to justification in philosophy; foundationalism and coherentism. I will discuss them briefly here, beginning with the former. As the term "foundationalism" suggests, its supporters hold that philosophical claims are justified if they build on some non-inferential base, such as indubitable beliefs or self-evident propositions. Some would say that it is an *axiomatic* view on justification.

One famous foundationalist in the history of philosophy is René Descartes (1596–1650). In his philosophy, Descartes explored *skepticism*. He set out to find something which one cannot be skeptical about, that is, something the existence of which cannot be doubted. When this "something" had been found, Descartes argued, it can provide a solid foundation for knowledge about other things. After some argumentation, Descartes found that one cannot be skeptical about one's own existence. His conclusion is often summarized as "cogito ergo sum," or "I think, therefore I am." After having found this absolute base for knowledge to build on, Descartes proceeded to construct a philosophical system which, in his view, was as reliable as the conviction one may have that one exists.

Later philosophers have argued Descartes's thesis can be proven false. The fact that the thought "I exist" appears in the world does not entail that the "I" it refers to exists; the thought "I exist" can be prompted by, for instance, chemical reactions or a computer program that creates an identity "I" which is not real. Therefore, the argument goes, Descartes did not discover an absolute foundation for knowledge and justification.

Coherentism

In coherentism, which is the main alternative to foundationalism, justification concerns coherence between various independently dubitable beliefs. One belief *A* is justified to the extent that it is consistent with other beliefs *B* and *C*, which in turn are justified to the extent they are likewise consistent. This implies that justification does not require certainty of particular beliefs. The moral claim that, for instance, "cheating is wrong," is justified in spite of the fact that there may be some uncertainty regarding whether the claim is universally valid. The reason why

it is justified is that it is consistent with other relevant beliefs, such as moral beliefs about trust and mutual obligations, and factual beliefs about social relationships and psychology.

Thus, coherentists are not concerned with certainty, but only coherence. This implies that a coherent set of beliefs providing justification for a certain claim can be mistaken. It may, for instance, be the case that it is a coherent set of prejudices. To deal with the problem that a set of beliefs may in fact be a coherent set of prejudices, I suggest that coherentism should include the requirement of constant re-assessment of existing beliefs. No belief in one's system of thought is ever immune to re-evaluation. To the contrary, for reasons of justification, it should be an integral part of one's intellectual enterprises to continuously subject one's own convictions to critical scrutiny. That is, or should be, a cornerstone of coherentism.

Reflective equilibrium

I adhere to a coherentist theory of moral justification which is commonly known as *reflective equilibrium*. Reflective equilibrium is the end-state of a deliberative process of moral inquiry, and also the name of the process itself, i.e., a method of moral inquiry.

As a theory of moral justification, reflective equilibrium is the theory that a moral claim is reason-giving if it is coherent with all other beliefs (in moral and non-moral matters) and with our stable and considered moral intuitions. For instance, the claim, "*ceteris paribus*, people who suffer should be helped," is justified not because it is true, but because it is coherent with all other beliefs and with our moral intuitions.

Among other things, moral reasons vary in strength and in relevance. The strength of a moral reason is relative to other elements in the equilibrium, not relative to some independent scale of measure. For instance, relieving suffering is sometimes a reason to intervene with a person's decisions, but respecting her autonomy is sometimes a reason to not intervene. A judgment on whether to intervene with the person's decisions is justified to the extent that it is balanced, taking all moral reasons, beliefs, and intuitions in consideration.

That is, in brief terms, reflective equilibrium as an end-state of a deliberative process in which moral claims are justified. But, it is common for the term to designate the deliberative process itself, i.e., a method of moral inquiry. As a method, reflective equilibrium is the deliberative process of reflecting on and revising moral judgments (and judgments related to them). In that process, empirical facts, risks and uncertainties, critical self-reflections of possible biases and other cognitive misbehaviors, and so on, must be taken into account. The process is goal-driven. It aims to seek a considered judgment on the matter at hand, i.e., a reflective equilibrium as an end-state, and is thus a process which is intended to identify what is reason-giving in a particular case or regarding a particular problem.

Writing the essay

Clarity and structure

Clarity in writing presupposes clarity in thought. One is often helped in clarifying one's thoughts by structuring them in bullet points. Consider this example, which reflects the first stages of organizing an argument:

- Main thesis: Respect for autonomy should be central in politics.
  - Definition: Being *autonomous* is to be *self-governed*.
  - Respecting a person's autonomy means that others do not interfere with how she leads her own life.
  - It may also mean that people should be provided with some things that are necessary for them to be autonomous, such as a proper education.
- Supporting theses
  - Autonomy is basic to what it is to be a human being.
  - Individuals in groups are always subject to the influences they exert on each other. It is in each individual's interest to be independent from these influences, at least to some extent.
  - The concept of autonomy may be helpful in explanations of moral concerns that other concepts in political philosophy, such as *liberty* and *justice*, fail to explain.

- Antitheses
  - Libertarianism: "Autonomy may be valuable, but it is irrelevant to politics; only rights matter politically."
  - Intersectional socialism: "Autonomy is politically relevant, but only in a non-individualist sense that is different from the current conceptualization."
- Conclusion: All things considered, the supporting theses provide stronger reasons to believe the main thesis.

When the various claims in the list have been sorted out and explained, the author is ready to consider how the complete message is best communicated to the reader. A good philosophy essay is well-structured. It is common to give the essay an *introduction* which explains the background and context of the problem, a *main section* which treats the main thesis at greater length, and a *concluding section* which sums up the discussion.

Communication

Contrary to the case in many other disciplines, it is common in philosophy to write in first-person singular. It is not only okay to write, "I will argue that" or "I think that," but in fact often preferable. Many students with a background in, for instance, mathematics, are used to writing, "we shall see that" or "we will demonstrate how." With few exceptions, this is unfamiliar to most philosophers. They do not feel included in the "we" that the author refers to unless the topic is strictly formal, such as in logic or decision theory; a philosophy teacher expect their student to present *her* views, not *ours*. Therefore, to communicate their message efficiently, I advise students to write in first-person singular.

Furthermore, it is common for philosophy students to formulate their claims as rhetorical questions. This is sometimes a style of writing, but sometimes it is a strategy for disguising the vagueness of a thought. Spelling out the same claim as a proposition often reveals that it is less clear than what first appears, and just as often more difficult to support than what the author wishes to signal by phrasing it as a rhetorical question. Therefore, rhetorical questions should generally be avoided.

Finally, and not to be underestimated, a good essay is aesthetically appealing. Of course, the look of an essay does not affect its content, but it matters to how the content is *perceived* by the reader; neat texts are judged more favorably than not-so-neat texts. Perhaps this should not be the case, yet it is. Therefore, students should seriously consider studying guides to typesetting and make sure that their essays are enjoyable also from an aesthetic point of view. (Maybe *this* text can be an inspiration.)

Concluding remarks

To conclude, the aim of writing philosophy is to communicate an abstract and often complex message efficiently. Among other things, this requires pedagogical sensitivity and clarity of thought.

Teachers expect their students to have basic knowledge of the topic they are writing about, including the background and context, that they are able to independently choose a problem to treat in their essay which is in fact possible to treat within the given limits in terms of deadline and page numbers, and that their arguments are clear, valid, and sound.

In philosophy, clarity, validity, and soundness are methodological concerns. This means that teachers are not as concerned with *what* their students argue, but rather *how* the argue; their arguments reflect their philosophical competence and talent.

Furthermore, claims of justification and claims of truth usually belong to separate categories. I have here mainly been concerned with the former. I have discussed foundationalism and coherentism as the main theories of justification. In my view, all claims of a moral nature should be justified with reference to reflective equilibrium, which is a coherentist theory of justification.

Finally, philosophical writing requires training. If one is about to write one's first philosophy essay, it is probably a good idea to team up with other students to read and comment critically on each others' essays before submitting them to the teacher.

P.S. Do *not* forget to put your name and e-mail address on the essay.